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Scott Yanow

Scott Yanow is one of the most respected jazz journalists and authors in the country today. His work includes books, liner notes, record reviews, and artist critiques.

Scott was interviewed via Zoom on October 22, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Scott Yanow with me today, who is an author, a jazz journalist, and quite a resource for jazz knowledge. That's the way I'm going to introduce you, I hope that works.

SY: Sure it does.

MR: I was reading about from your website your experience of going to college with LPs and I really related to that. And your description, it was quite a leap you made in a short amount of time from Pete Fountain to John Coltrane and Pharoah Sanders. Can you remember how that music affected you, expanding your listening palate back then?

SY: Remember this is like [gap]. 1970 is when I first discovered Dixieland, it was a local radio show, and I noticed in the *Los Angeles Times* it mentioned it, it was like 5 to 6 PM on an FM station, Monday through Friday. So I thought well this is happy music, I'll see what this is like. And it took a couple of days and then I was addicted to that. And then about six months later I discovered Chuck Cecil's Swingin' Years and I got into the Swing Era. But when I went to college all I listened to basically was Dixieland and swing for the first month or two. And I happened to be in a dormitory where there were a lot of musicians and they looked at my records, I had 25 records and they'd say, "Oh, what a huge collection." You know they thought 25 was huge, of LPs, and they'd look through it and see Dixieland and Al Hirt and Pete Fountain. And they thought I was crazy of course. Worth remembering is Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie, and I didn't know anything about them at all so I went to a used record store and for $1.99 I saw a Charlie Parker record that had a lot of unfamiliar tunes like "Night in Tunisia" and "Groovin' High." But it did have one song I'd heard of called "White Christmas." And I said, "I've heard this one" because there was a request for it on the radio broadcasting it. So I listened to that each day three or four times, it took me a little while to get into it. But by the end of the week the doors were open. And then I was just very curious about all other eras of jazz. So very quickly I went through and I loved Eric Dolphy and I got into Thelonious Monk and within a few months I was into John Coltrane, not just his early stuff but the latest screaming things he did with Pharoah Sanders and that's when the musicians I knew were sure that I was crazy [gap].

MR: It's so interesting you say that because I shouldn't talk about myself but very briefly I went out to get my first John Coltrane record because someone said, "You should listen to him." And I picked up "Om." And that was not a great place to start for me, and I'm afraid it scared me off for quite a while.

SY: But you know it's just the basic idea I liked to hear how it all evolved and how it all connects together. And because I was lucky enough to start with Dixieland and the 1920s jazz, I still love listening to that today, where most critics and jazz journalists, they don't go further back from Charlie Parker, usually. You know you have Benny Goodman and Duke Ellington, but they're not really going to go back to the earliest music because the recording quality doesn't agree with them and it seems too simple. They don't quite understand or appreciate how it all connects together.

MR: Do you feel that there's a determination on their part that that music wasn't really an art form or worthy of being an art form, thus worthy of critiquing?

SY: Well I always thought the art form connection to jazz was kind of overdone to tell you the truth. Now of course it was an art form from the very beginning. I mean Buddy Bolden most likely played music that could be considered artistic, and certainly by the time recordings were made of the Original Dixieland Jazz Band, I mean it's way ahead of its time, you know, compared to most of the music that was recorded. Most of the music from 1917 or so that's on records is really unlistenable at this point, you know because it's just too primitive or it's just very predictable. But jazz still sounds fresh, even if it's over 100 years old, if it's well played you know.

MR: Can we pursue that a little bit? About the art form. Because I've been fascinated by that over the years and that it kind of went hand in hand with losing much of the audience it seems like, once jazz became an art form it lost some popularity and became almost like classical music is in the United States.

SY: The thing about art form is fine if you're going after grants or you want Congress to declare jazz you know America's National Treasure. That's all nice. But when it comes to building up an audience I mean jazz is basically the most fun music in the world, it's the most adventurous music. You know the idea of seeing someone, seeing a group come on stage and make up the music as they go along, which in some more advanced areas of jazz it's practically free improvisation. That's exciting, it's must more exciting to me than seeing a pop group try to recreate their records on stage, you know with a captive audience. And that the problem with jazz being declared an art form, it was fine in the 40s, you know because you know they were trying to separate jazz from popular music. But by doing that you end up separating jazz from popular music and you know jazz got rid of the — for a variety of reasons jazz was no longer being played for dancers even though the music itself is danceable much of the time. And by doing that you lost a lot of

the audience. You know the audience went to rhythm & blues and eventually rock & roll and Motown and everything else. And if you look at what the most popular music in the world is generally it's danceable music. Even in jazz, one of the most popular styles, well Latin jazz you know, and swing is still popular, and there are some parts of fusion that are rock oriented was danceable. That's much more popular than bebop or hard bop, and yet bebop and hard bop are danceable, it's just that it's not danceable if you don't have a dance floor.

MR: That's true. I love the practical considerations that come into what happens to music. "Well I could dance to it but there's no music because this place seats like 40 people and there's no place to move around."

SY: No. You can't dance to it if there's nowhere to dance.

MR: Yeah. Have you ever had an occasion, oh at a cocktail party or something, where you get into a discussion about what you do and someone asks you to explain what the heck are these musicians doing after they play the melody? They start doing this stuff and I get lost." Do you have a way of explaining that in layman's terms?

SY: Well you know of course it would depend on what, who it is that's playing, but generally they are playing off of the chord changes, they're playing the song but they're not stating the melody over and over again. That if you're listening closely you could tell let's say if they're playing a standard song you could tell — by listening closely you could tell where it starts again, where the chorus begins, and they're basically creating melodies on the song itself. They do that in free jazz, the idea is just to come up with new ideas and new themes along the way. And if you just listen closely and have an open mind, definitely that's all you can do.

MR: Does — this is a wide open question: does music need to have a meaning beyond the fact that it's music?

SY: No. It doesn't have to. Some songs and some musicians do look for deeper meaning in their music but quite often what they're doing is they're playing the song or they're playing what they're feeling at the moment. You know I mean the way to judge or appreciate jazz is really just does it move you and is it colorful and do you enjoy it. You know it's really up to the individual.

MR: Yeah, I like that answer and I asked it partly because you had talked about bop and the fact that sometimes the musicians sacrificed feeling for precision, and emotion for speed.

SY: Well in classic bebop I mean it was such a virtuosic music, you know the music from the mid-40s until 1950 or so that Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker and many others were playing. There is feeling but the notes are often flying by so fast that you know the technique sort of overrides it to an extent. But you know if, the thing about Charlie Parker let's say you know like who I've always regarded as quite arguably the greatest

saxophonist ever, if you slow down his solos to half speed you find that every note makes sense much of the time. It blazes by, you can't quite follow it if you're hearing it for the first time or so, but if you listen to it at a slower speed it's all there, there's a definite logic.

MR: Good point. So you got a degree in accounting and you ended up as a jazz editor for *Record Review,* was there a point where you consciously said I think I'll try to make a living writing about jazz?

SY: It's a difficult profession really. If the musicians don't get paid well then you should look at the average jazz writer. But it is possible to make a living from it but you basically have to hustle all the time and you have to be a freelancer and be open to a wide variety of assignments. But yes there was a time, I mean it got to the point where, because I spent so much time on jazz my accounting career was declining anyway and it finally reached a point where I was making more money from doing jazz than accounting so I just said well the accounting is interfering with my life so I'll take a chance.

MR: So I'm trying to picture you, you know, writing some of your early record reviews and most likely from LPs. Do you recall the listening process before you wrote? Did you listen multiple times to a record? Did you play certain tracks more than once? That kind of thing.

SY: Yeah, the key is for me, is to listen to it closely once and to take notes along the way. And if the music seems too difficult or complex for me then I listen to it again. You know you listen to it until you can appreciate its good and bad points really. Most of the time if I put on a straight ahead jazz record, most of the time after one listen I pretty much can describe the music to readers.

MR: Okay, so we had an email exchange about this comment that was written by any number of people about writing about music is like dancing about architecture. And is the fact that music is an abstract, mostly abstract art form, is it a challenge to put it into words for you? Or was it early on?

SY: Not really. You know I mean that quote might have been said by Thelonious Monk at least I know it's been ascribed to him once, I don't know it's probably been around for a hundred years. No I've never really had difficulty because the main purpose in writing a review is to describe the music enough to readers so they'll have an idea of whether they'll like it or not. Whether I enjoy it or not is less important than whether it's something that they would want to acquire. So it's just a matter of describing what does it sound like, you know? Without comparing it too much to other musicians, you know how does it sound compared to other music of the time period and to other recordings that they've done in the past. And it's not that hard. You know maybe it's because I've had this training when I was with *Record Review* which was the magazine I wrote for from

1977 to 1984, you know back a million years ago, I had, among other things I had a column called "Shorts" in which I reviewed about twenty albums, maybe thirty words apiece. It was all on one page and I'd give it a little grade at the end. And I learned how to — not to waste words really. Just what's on the record and what does it sound like. And then if you just give those two basic things to readers they should be able to decide.

MR: Yeah and then they go to the record store, like the old days where we used to thumb through all the records and they might find the one you're describing.

SY: Yeah. And you know plus now they buy through the Internet or buy it somewhere else, but it's still the same basic idea, really. You know I mean if it's a — say it's a fusion record I'll mention somewhere along the way that it's rock oriented or that they're using electronic instruments and that way people that are into that music like have an idea that maybe it's something that will interest them.

MR: So in those 30-word summarizing pattern, when you get into more lengthy reviews, at what point does your personal opinion start to enter into your writing?

SY: Well there's always a certain amount of that anyway because you have to edit it and you are — is it a favorable review or was the album a disappointment for one reason or another? You know there's a certain amount of that, but that should be secondary to just describing what it sounds like and being accurate you know in order to describe it right, and for the readers, you know it's up to them, to a certain extent, to maybe read a few other things from each writer to get an idea of whether their taste is similar to yours. Because a lot of times I'll read stuff and I'll know that maybe this is an album that I would like but the writer, the journalist, obviously doesn't like it. You know they write it off, they're not into swing, and I'll say well, he's saying it's a swing record so maybe it'll be interesting to me. You know so, you know there should be enough clues in the reviews so the reader will have an idea.

MR: Have you ever had occasion to dislike a record so much that you pass on the review?

SY: Once in a great while. If it's not jazz, if it's outside of jazz or say it's a rap record or something, then I won't even review it. And if it's a situation, which is true of several of the magazines I write for where I get to choose what I'd like to review, if I put it on and it's kind of dull then I think well maybe some other time and I'll switch to another record. But if you're assigned something, like say for *DownBeat* or *Jazz-Is* then I pretty much have to review it, but in most cases they assign me things that are complementary to my tastes anyway.

MR: Okay. Some of our best known and iconic musicians, jazz musicians, have taken a turn at trying to enter the pop market or become more popular. Have you had instances where you're reviewing some of our heroes and all of a sudden they're covering Beatles songs or something like that?

SY: Well they'll do that once in a while, and I don't blame them for trying to make some more money, but on the other hand you know my responsibility is really towards my readers. It's not towards musicians, it's certainly not toward other critics. Because sometimes you read something from a journalist and they're obviously trying to impress, you know, other writers. Or they're trying to cozy up to musicians. But no, I don't, I want the readers to know that if they're going to spend fifteen or twenty dollars on a CD it'll most likely be something that they'll like, or something that's at least in a style of music that interests them.

MR: What kind of feedback over the years have you received from the artists you review? Let me rephrase. Are you more likely to get contacted by aggravated musicians who didn't like what you wrote rather than people thanking you for your review?

SY: Pretty even, really. When you are a jazz critic you have to know that if a musician compliments you that means if you liked their last record. That means if they say you are a great writer that means you wrote a great review for them. And if you wrote a negative review then you're a bum. Like, so you can't really take their opinions too seriously, much of the time, unless it's someone you know and they're being really honest about it. I mean it's kind of funny, there was one saxophonist who because of the Internet you know reviews stay up there forever. And I wrote something for the *All Music Guide* maybe in 1995 on him, and he has criticized the review I wrote, you know thirty years ago. So I said well that's comforting because I know that if you don't like what I write about your current record I'm not going to hear from you until 2050.

MR: I recall doing an interview with a wonderful guy, a veteran trombonist. And I happened to bring up something that Gary Giddins wrote. And he immediately said, "Does he play anything? Has he ever played anything?" Like he didn't even let me finish my sentence, it was like that was the hurdle for him in order to give some kind of credence to what Gary wrote. Had he played something. Do you think that's important?

SY: Yeah it's important for a jazz critic to have as much knowledge as possible, and if you play a little bit of music that's good. But it's not necessary. I mean Whitney Balliet, the best of all writers on jazz, he was always my favorite. You could read his reviews and you could almost hear the music of the people he's writing about. And I think he played drums a little bit but he didn't really play music very often. It's not necessary at all. I mean if it's musicians reviewing musicians it's going to be an obvious conflict of interest eventually because they might be complimenting them because they want to get a gig. Or maybe they're a friend of theirs and you know it's not that way. It's a different profession. I mean writers are not frustrated musicians. Now if you hear some of them playing you might say they're frustrating musicians, but not frustrated.

MR: Okay.

SY: [inaudible]

MR: I think musicians writing about musicians could tend to also use too much sort of inside language that the average reader might find a little alienating.

SY: Well you know you can't have an attitude in your writing. I mean there are some writers like I feel like I need a dictionary to figure out what they're talking about. And that's not what you're aiming for. I use small words. I mean my vocabulary is not that large. If I have to know French to try to be able to figure out what they're saying then they've failed.

MR: Okay. Well speaking of words, I wanted to ask you about I've recently been reading your *Jazz Singers* book and by the way, now I own two copies because Jeannie Cheatham sent me your book. So she must have liked what you wrote about her. And a couple of things I wanted to mention, I was very happy to turn to page 233 under Nancy Wilson and see my favorite LP of all time, the one she did with Cannonball. The other thing I enjoyed was your talk about what makes a jazz singer. And if you don't mind I wonder if you could share your perspective on that again.

SY: It's always a tricky thing because with jazz there's a lot of instances where it's borderline. Is Rosemary Clooney a jazz singer? Well she sings jazz tunes and she swings. But does she improvise much? You know one could debate about that. And of course one always debates about Frank Sinatra and Tony Bennett. Are they really jazz singers? Well sort of and sort of not. You know. Where someone like Kurt Elling or Betty Carter or Mel Torme, they're definitely jazz singers. So I mean the quality that is needed is that they need to improvise to a certain extent. Not scat sing but be able to at least in their phrasing and in their use of words make the song their own really.

MR: Yeah there's been a number of singers over the years who have come out with the debut album and I don't know if it's their choice or the record companies and they'll get Ron Carter and people of that talent level to play behind them. And when you listen to it you say well it's a jazz trio but it's not really a jazz singer.

SY: Like I say, it's tricky. [inaudible] different singers much of the time but they might not sing jazz a hundred percent of the time. You just have to look at their overall career and then they are good musicians but they're just singing straight. Generally if the singer does the song the same way one month to another they're probably not a jazz singer. I mean with someone like Tony Bennett, he'll perform a song and he'll sing a chorus straight, then there'll be half a chorus of sidemen playing, and then he comes back on and finishes the song. So I went to see him once and every song was two choruses.

MR: I see.

SY: That doesn't mean he's not good and that doesn't mean that he didn't put on an enjoyable show.

MR: Yes. Here's what you wrote about Bing Crosby. "He's probably the first great white male jazz singer who was not a musician." So it begs the question when does a singer get to be considered a musician and most singers I think would object to that statement. I'm not sure most, but a lot of them would. In your mind when does a singer become a musician?

SY: Well I guess I would amend that statement too, because that was written like twenty years ago. I think I would say he was the first white jazz singer, important white jazz singer who was not an instrumentalist. Because singers are generally musicians too, it's just that some of them are good musicians and some of them are masterful ones. So I would probably amend that statement.

MR: Well I didn't disagree with the statement because some singers, who know the craft, who know their keys and who know how things work on stage, then to me okay I'm working with another musician. Those singers who don't know those things we tend to wish they did I guess is the best way I can put it.

SY: A lot of them are show biz performers, you know, so that's a little different. They're not necessarily jazz singers.

MR: Um hum. Well a book like your *Jazz Singers* takes some serious organization and planning. How do you know when you're done with a book like this?

SY: The thing is it's kind of crazy because there are so many singers, and you know when I was writing the book it seemed like I'd discover five new singers, five current singers that were new every week. So it was getting to the point where if I don't cut off the book now it's going to be three times as big. When I did a book on jazz guitarists then there would be maybe one new guitarist a week. But with singers it just seemed like they were all over the place. And most of them are good. So it was difficult because I wanted to include a lot of local singers who were talented and who grew up to become famous. So that's why my list had 500 and it could have been 2000 really. But I had to cut it off finally. There are other ones, but in the current scene there were just so many.

MR: It would have been an extremely thick book also.

SY: Yes, definitely.

MR: I was wondering about your choice of adjectives, using words to describe the singers right off the bat, do you have, I'm almost picturing a list of adjectives that you go to that you think are relevant for this person and that you haven't used in a while.

SY: Yeah pretty much. You know the hardest part about writing a book like that where you're describing the style of maybe 500 people is not to have too much repetition. So if you call someone colorful you don't want to use that word too soon again. Maybe four entries later. It's just a matter of making them readable really. A lot of them are similar to each other anyway. So no, I didn't have a list really, just whatever comes. And that's usually how I write. I usually don't write with an outline either. I mean I might have a little

outline just so I know how a book's going to progress but in general it's pretty spontaneous. And then I'll go back and proofread it several times and fix anything that might have been repetitious or didn't fit.

MR: Do you have other people proofread your work?

SY: Not usually. I mean in the case of a couple of books the publishers had proofreaders there and it was just a matter of putting accents over French names and Spanish names and those kind of things. But in general no one's ever gone through my book and said this is factually wrong. So if it's a mistake it's mine.

MR: Okay. Well has your fact checking, the way we get our information obviously has progressed a lot since your career started as a writer. Has the Internet made your life easier or has it thrown up other issues you hadn't expected?

SY: Mostly easier, really. I mean in the old days, 70s and 80s let's say, you wrote a letter to England to request an album it took two weeks to get there and then it'd take two weeks to get a response and maybe the album so you've got four weeks before you receive what it is you asked for. Where now if you send — obviously you send an email, they get it a couple of seconds later and they can respond quickly. It might still take two weeks for the record to get here but at least the correspondence is so much faster. I mean I'll always appreciate email, because I remember that time when you had to wait and wait. But that's just how it was. It's easier also in being able to gather information. You know instead of going to a library or even looking in my books, I can look things up very quickly. I mean you have to take a lot of it with a grain of salt because some of it is just not accurate you know. I could look in Wikipedia, 80 percent of the time it's correct but every once in a while there'll be something that isn't, so you have to check several places.

MR: I see. Once you hear the same thing from two or three sources you feel better about using it?

SY: Yeah, especially like birth dates, you know if they're vintage performers there might be three different dates for them and you have to look it up and see. And you don't guess which one is probably the most accurate, and this kind of thing. But yeah, it's made it easier. I mean of course emails and text messages are a constant distraction so you have to be able to not pay too much attention in maybe five minutes and probably actually try to get the work done.

MR: Are you a writer that works better with a deadline?

SY: If I don't have a deadline I'll give myself one. And I always try to give myself a deadline in general of maybe a week or at least several days before the people expect it. Because no one ever complains if I sent in something too early.

MR: That's good for the — in regards to the competition with other writers. Because probably not everybody is that way.

SY: It sort of is. I mean when you're a jazz writer and you're freelancing you're your own boss, it's really your own business. And you have to look at it that way. I live off of "to-do" lists. I have constant to-do lists. So that way if I have, because sometimes I have eight or ten assignments going on at once. Now they're not all due today, they're due over the next three weeks or so. So I write down what day I'm going to work on it. [inaudible] It's just a matter of being organized, because if you're organized you can get an awful lot out.

MR: Is there a bit of an industry standard about how to charge for what you do?

SY: I have no idea what other people charge. Maybe I don't have the courage to ask them. And I figure if I ask them it's kind of invading their privacy and then they don't ask me because you know, if I gave out that information someone would try to undercut me of course, or vice versa.

MR: Right. Everybody's sort of protecting themselves I guess with that kind of information.

SY: I don't know what other people charge for liner notes, I just know what I do. But I know that people don't wince, you know they don't look at me with horror when I give them the price so I figure I'm on the right track.

MR: And have you ever had to bargain with somebody to get a sort of coveted gig?

SY: I didn't quite understand?

MR: Well I'm wondering if you ever had a chance to you know have a long term writing assignment but you had to bargain with the people about the price?

SY: Oh occasionally. You know most of the time it's reasonable. Because I try not to overcharge and most of the time I let them name the price, and then I'll say well you know how about this instead. And it works. You know you have to have a little bit of courage about that, but you also have to know what you're worth to an extent. I mean if I did liner notes for fifty dollars everybody would use me but I'd never make any money and you'd also have less respect. And this is what I tell musicians on a slightly different topic when they let their music get streamed. If you give something away for free then it's considered worthless you know. If you can't charge a reasonable price then you know then you don't think that highly of yourself and the people that are hiring you aren't going to think that highly of you. They won't respect you as much. Now on the other hand you don't want to overcharge and bankrupt them for [inaudible] you know you have to find a balance, see what's reasonable.

MR: You know that's a slippery slope because people feel they need to take advantage of this amazing spread of information, "Well I'd better get my music on there too." But the return on it has become very low if anything.

SY: Definitely. It's just a matter of knowing what you're worth really, and don't undersell yourself but on the other hand being realistic about it.

MR: Yeah. What's your opinion about, we were going back a little bit to the concept of jazz as an art form. Do you have any opinion about the thriving business of jazz education in the country?

SY: Well I think jazz education is a good thing in that it's good when it gives young musicians the fundamentals and the basics. How do you play your instrument properly. How do you improvise, that sort of thing. But I think the attitude should be when you've graduated from school, then you're a beginner, you qualify to be a beginner. You're not a masterful musician because you went to Berklee. You might be anyway, because a lot of masterful players do that. But it's just the beginning. Now you have to get experience on stage and you've got to play with musicians who hopefully are older than yourself and more experienced and learn from it. I mean there's not that many Art Blakeys left in the world but if you should find a similar musician, find someone who's willing to play with younger players and who you can learn from.

MR: Yeah.

SY: This really can't be taught, you know, all you can do is just make sure that you're not making mistakes by your fingering being wrong or your having a bad mouthpiece.

MR: Yeah. I think you just gave me a quote that I will use and I will attribute to you and that is if you graduate from music school you're ready to be a beginner. I like that. When we transcribe this I gotta make sure I've got it word for word.

SY: Oh that's quite all right.

MR: Well your point about really learning how to play the music involves post-education and getting up on stage with people that are better than you or more experienced.

SY: Yeah because if you're only playing with musicians your own age after a while you won't be able to learn as much, you can develop some skills but there are things that veterans can teach you after having played on stage for twenty or thirty or longer years.

MR: Has there been a period of years for whatever reason jazz journalism and authorship was more difficult than others?

SY: In the older days, say oh 1970 or so, there were less recordings coming out and there were less reviews to write. But then again you had some really tremendous writers, you know, some of the ones who I read when I was starting out were just great. And they all had their faults and their good points, but I mean my early heroes were Leonard Feather because he was so dominant during that era, even though you know he's not perfect and there are certain things — I could talk about him for an hour. Leonard Feather, Nat Hentoff, and Stanley Dance who even though he hated bebop he was great when he talked about swing. You know he interviewed all these people, and Whitney Balliet I discovered after a little while, who was just a poetic writer, and the last, the only one really that's still with us is Dan Morgenstern. I read him early on. And all three were

giants. We now have a lot more writers I think but there's no one that dominates the field. You know Garry Giddins is great, you know he's my generation. He and Francis Davis, you know, I rate them both very high. The current writers, also are quite good, I just can't think of any one that I would pick out and see oh he's the best one or she's the best one right now.

MR: What about the — every few years there is a controversy or at least a debate is raised about who owns jazz. Is jazz an African-American art form or is it — what happened to the white innovators? Have you ever gotten in the middle of that subject matter?

SY: Not too much, I usually avoid it. But to tell you the truth now jazz was founded by African-Americans and it's a great music but there are a couple of statements that are said that quite often I don't agree with. Jazz is not America's only art form and it's not only an American art form. I mean what's ragtime and what is tap dancing and movies and even country music to an extent. They are all art forms and they're not jazz and that's different. So jazz isn't the only one. And also jazz was purely American up until about 1920 or so and then at that point in time recordings became available around the world and at that point Europeans could play jazz. During the 30s they were able to play, and South Americans can. It's not only American and it's not only by African-Americans because there have been white innovators since the 20s. It was founded by the blacks and you could say it's their heritage, you know one aspect of their heritage. But it belongs to anyone with open ears — at a concert a musician who is creative enough and skilled enough to be able to play it.

MR: Do you have an opinion about what I think is sometimes an overused word and that is the term "genius." What makes a person or an artist rise to the level of a genius?

SY: I don't really know. You know that word is definitely overused. I mean you could be a genius in one area, a musical genius, and not necessarily be smart in other aspects of your life. I think if someone comes up with a completely new way of playing jazz, like Charlie Parker or someone who has just so many innovations in their career like Duke Ellington, you'd call them geniuses. But if someone plays their instrument well and they have a nice sound you know genius is kind of overused.

MR: Do you have a short list of your favorite jazz artists?

SY: Well it wouldn't be short of course, you know I can name a bunch. I think there are certain — my favorites who — well Louis Armstrong is my favorite of all of them. You know he's my favorite jazz artist and there's so much joy in his playing from all aspects of his career, any period. I love the way he phrases and the sound. But if I were to name two — the ones I think are the obvious ones that are the most important to jazz history there'd be six: Louis Armstrong, Duke Ellington, Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, Miles Davis and John Coltrane. I don't think anybody's going to argue too much with that. You

can add another dozen to that from Ornette Coleman, maybe Chick Corea and Count Basie and you know, many, many others. But basically I have hundreds of favorites. So you'd have to say what time period.

MR: Yes exactly. Well I —

SY: There's millions you know.

MR: I like the bulletin board behind you, I wonder what makes your bulletin board?

SY: If there is a colorful picture I happen to get or if it's something that's humorous. I'm going after three more but I don't have the space.

MR: Well speaking of humor, I did a double take on your website when I read some of your testimonials. I said I have to get some of these. For instance Cab Calloway who said "Scott Yanow is hep to the jive." And you have one from Louis Armstrong next to King Oliver's, "Scott Yanow is my biggest inspiration of all the cats."

SY: I want to see if anybody's paying attention you know. But I mean there's people there that I never met.

MR: Yes.

SY: But sometimes you read resumes and there'll be endless testimonials. Oh this person played at my wedding and you know, that's all nice but —

MR: Yeah, and the people who include every person they ever backed up, even though they might have been in a 30-piece orchestra, a one time shot, right. "Played on stage with —"

SY: Yeah you have to make it colorful.

MR: What's on your to-do list at the moment?

SY: I don't know. I don't know what I'm doing. I've been listening to a lot of re-issues but I mean recently I listened to some Stan Kenton ballad albums because I reviewed it for something, for one magazine. And then a George Duke album that actually has him playing jazz in the early 70s. But as far as new music goes, I don't know there's an Anat Cohen record, a Brazilian album, and I'm looking forward to getting the John Coltrane "A Love Supreme" the live version that just came out. But it's on a moment's notice. When it doubt I'll put on Eddie Condon. The thing is sometimes people get depressed and I say, "Well, put on Dixieland, the world's happiest music, you'll be happy."

MR: Yes and I want to take note that you mentioned John Coltrane followed by the phrase, "A Moment's Notice." Well done, even if it was an improvisation.

SY: That's in my mind you know. But I'm constantly jumping between eras you know, what I listen to. You know ever since I first got into jazz fifty years ago I've never been bored, except when I'm away from it.

MR: Oh, that's a good way to put it. How many hours a day do you write normally?

SY: It's constant, you know, I mean four or five hours. Sometimes longer, sometimes less. But if I'm not writing I almost always have jazz on on the stereo.

MR: Do you ever put anything on like Mozart to sort of reset your ears for a while?

SY: No. I think I have three classical albums. What I'll do is I'll switch styles, yeah. When you go from swing to completely avante garde, or fusion to bebop, then you're not listening to the same music all the time anyway. And it's just — classical music I mean if I didn't get into jazz maybe I would have gotten into that, but you know I spend a lot of time listening to 100 Years of Jazz, I really can't spend the time listening to 400 years of classical. There's just no time.

MR: Yeah, that's an interesting statement and it's fascinating to me how many stylistic changes there have been in a hundred years, and I guess if jazz started about the same time, congealed as a music when recording started, which was very fortuitous for it.

SY: Yeah it's a tricky thing. I mean the evolution of jazz on record is really fascinating from the 1917 to the late 70s and maybe early 80s, it's just like a constant race towards freedom. You know each style is a little freer than the one before and — but it got to the point where okay you've got Cecil Taylor and how do you get freer than that? So then from that point on musicians had to use aspects of the past along with their own personality and their own ideas, combine things together. And it's made it difficult because there are no names for any of the styles anymore, any of the styles since — let's say since 1980. I mean you might have retro swing, okay that's people reviving aspects of swing or you might have MBase the Steve Coleman stuff or but you might say there's always the young lions, the hard bop stuff, but basically no new styles. But on the other hand there's a thousand new styles. It's like what do you call Pat Methany's music? You know? And what's John Scofield play? I don't know. What's Jason Moran doing? So in a way it makes it look like jazz isn't evolving even though it is, it just is evolving in an infinite number of directions at once rather than one main direction. I don't know. It makes the music rewarding to listen to because there's so many more surprises.

MR: Yeah. You have to — it makes it harder for you to put a label on it I guess.

SY: Yeah for fusion what does the music for the last four years sound like? [inaudible] There are more names, but there aren't many.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation and I admire you for finding this career and sticking with it for so long, and what we call big ears between musicians and you obviously have big ears for all the styles and appreciate them. And I congratulate you for that.

SY: Well thank you, well it's great fun. I mean I have a 30-second commute to work. I could complain and say you have to listen to records all day long.

MR: Well great. Thanks for your time today. I'm going to pause our recording and then we'll say our good-byes.

SY: Okay well thanks for having me, it's been great fun.

MR: All right.